



HIGHER HEALTH

2024

POLICY ON ASSESSMENT



Policy on Assessment

Version Number	01
Version Date	March 2024
Author	Nireen Naidoo
Designation	Executive Manager: Office of the CEO
Reviewed by	EXCO
Review Date	

Approved by	Higher Health Board
Signed on behalf of the Board:	Prof R Ahluwalia
Signature	
Approval Date	20 March 2024
Effective Date	21 March 2024
Date of next Review	20 March 2027

Table of Contents

Glossary	3
1. Background	8
2. Purpose.....	8
3. Legislative and Regulatory Framework.....	8
4. Scope and Application	8
5. Policy Statement	9
5.1 Principles.....	9
5.2 Quality assurance of Internal and Final Assessments.....	9
5.3 Competency-based Assessments	10
5.4 Content of Assessment.....	11
5.5 Implementation of Assessments	12
5.6 Assessment Irregularities	13
5.7 Approval of final results	13
6. Roles and Responsibilities	13
6.1 Higher Health.....	13
6.2 QCTO (Quality Council for Trades and Occupations)	15
7. Appeals	15
8. Reporting.....	15
9. Applicability	15

Glossary

“Assessment body” means a department of education or an entity accredited/ delegated by a Quality Council to conduct external summative assessment and moderate site-based assessment for specified qualifications, part-qualifications, professional designations, or prior learning.

“Assessment criteria” means the standards used to guide learning and assess learner achievement and/ or evaluate and certify competence.

“Assessment” means the process used to identify, gather and interpret information and evidence against the required competencies in a qualification, part-qualification, or professional designation in order to make a judgement about a learner’s achievement. Assessment can be formal, non-formal or informal; assessment can be of learning already done, or towards learning to inform and shape teaching and learning still to be done.

“Assessor” means a person able to conduct high-quality internal and external assessment for specific qualifications, part-qualifications, or professional designations. Appropriately qualified lecturers, teachers, educators, trainers, examiners, moderators, chief markers, markers, Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL) specialists, and Credit Accumulation and Transfer (CAT) officials are all examples of assessors.

“Authentic assessment” means using creative learning experiences to test learners' skills and knowledge in realistic situations.

“Bias” means assessment practices that hinder or advantage particular learners or groups of learners. An absence of bias is sought, where all learners and educators are treated with equal respect and consideration regardless of social, economic, cultural, faith-based, ethnic, gender or other differences, and where disabled learners and educators are given appropriate support.

“Blended learning” means learning and assessment based on a variety of modes, types, sites, outputs, contexts, platforms and other aspects including contact and technology-mediated learning.

“Credibility” means a respected process or product which results from a fair, valid, and reliable validation process designed to enhance the quality of a qualification, part-qualification, or professional designation.

“Credits” means the amount of learning contained in a qualification or part-qualification whereby one credit is equal to ten (10) notional learning hours.

“Curriculum” for the purposes of this Policy means requirements for learner achievement of a qualification or part-qualification in terms of knowledge, skills, and where relevant, work experience.

“Diagnostic assessment” means assessment conducted before teaching or training starts, for the purposes of identifying learners’ strengths and weaknesses, in order to use the associated information for the purposes of creating suitable learning environments.

“Dynamic assessment” means assessment practices in which mediation, learning, testing, frequent feedback to learners and systematic monitoring of changes in learning are explicit parts of the learning context. The goal of dynamic assessment is to see whether, by how much and in what ways those being assessed change as a result of being presented with opportunities to learn.

“e-Assessment” means any type of assessment that involves an electronic component and incorporates one or more of e-testing, e-portfolios and e-marking.

“Educator” is an inclusive term referring to teachers, lecturers, facilitators, assessors, moderators, and others teaching, educating, training, facilitating, assessing, or enabling learning in learning contexts across the board.

“e-learning” means a mode of teaching and learning that makes use of technology-mediated features.

“Evaluation of learning” means a process involving gathering evidence and making informed judgements about a learning programme, or module or component of a learning programme; or its curriculum, learning materials or assessment; or its impact on learners or society. Evaluation involves making a judgement about the worth, merit or impact of learning or a programme of learning.

“Examiner” means a qualified and competent person appointed to develop, administer, and oversee a formal assessment, including a person appointed to develop assessment instruments (such as exam papers, marking guidelines, and others). An examiner may be an educator.

“External assessment” means assessment developed by a qualified and competent person or body not directly involved in the development and/or delivery of the learning being assessed.

“Fairness” in assessment means that learners are assessed on what they know and have been taught; where questions are set in relation to the cognitive and affective curriculum covered in the teaching and learning; in the case of Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL), there has been preparation for the competent mediation of the required knowledge and other competencies; and that there is no bias towards any learners on the basis of social class, ethnicity, gender, or disability.

“Feedback” means specific reporting from the teacher to the learner or between learners, on how they have performed in an assessment activity, regardless of the level of formality of the assessment activity. Feedback specifies what was done well, and why, and provides clear guidance regarding what is missing or still needs development in learners’ texts, performances or demonstrations, in order to enhance learning.

“Final Integrated Supervised Assessment (FISA)” means a supervised final assessment for which assessment processes, tools, and results are recorded towards the achievement of a QCTO skills programme, conducted under examination conditions.

“Formal assessment” means assessment for which assessment processes, tools, and results are recorded towards achievement of a qualification, part-qualification or professional designation.

“Formal learning” means learning that occurs in an organised and structured education and training environment and that is explicitly designated as such. Formal learning leads to the awarding of a qualification or part-qualification registered on the NQF.

“Formative assessment” means a range of formal, non-formal, and informal ongoing assessment procedures used to focus teaching and learning activities to improve learner attainment.

“Informal assessment” for the purposes of this Policy means any judgements made or feedback given in the course of teaching and learning activities. Informal assessments may be in written form but are not usually recorded.

“Informal learning” means learning that results from daily activities related to paid or unpaid work, family or community life, or leisure, including incidental learning.

“Integrated assessment” means assessment which involves all the differing types of assessment tasks required for a particular qualification, part-qualification, or professional designation, such as written assessment of theory and practical demonstration of competence. For skills Programmes, the QCTO refers to this assessment as FISA.

“Integrity” for the purposes of this Policy means honesty and transparency in every part of the assessment process, including that assessment questions must be based on work actually covered; learners must at all times be honest about what they offer to be assessed; markers must strive to understand what is offered by learners for assessment, and to grade it fairly at all times; and moderators must moderate a fair sample of examples against a fair range of cases.

“Internal assessment” means any assessment conducted internally by a provider of learning. It is assessment conducted by a person, institution or body directly involved in the development and/or delivery of the learning being assessed.

“Learner” is an inclusive term referring to anyone learning, including pupils, students, apprentices, interns, learners in learnerships, people doing training, and people learning non-formally and informally as well as people enrolled for particular qualifications or part-qualifications, and people learning in contact, distance, and self-study contexts at all levels in the system.

“Learning outcomes” mean the contextually demonstrated end-products of specific learning processes, which include knowledge, skills and values.

“Learning pathway” means sequencing of qualifications that allows learners to move vertically,

diagonally, and in some cases horizontally, through NQF levels giving learners recognition for full or partially completed qualifications or part-qualifications. Learning pathways can also lead to professional designations, when learning pathways include periods of structured work experience over and above qualifications.

“Mixed-mode or multi-modal learning” means learning that makes use of different learning sites and different forms of delivery including but not limited to face-to-face, distance and e-learning, and fulltime, part-time, and block-release study.

“Moderation” in assessment means internal and external verification that an assessment system is credible and that assessors and learners behave in an ethical way; and that assessments are fair, valid, reliable and practicable.

“National assessment policy” for the purposes of this Policy means all policies that are addressed to all organisations of a particular type in South Africa.

“National Learners’ Records Database (NLRD)” means the electronic management information system of the NQF under the authority of SAQA, which contains records of qualifications, part-qualifications, learner achievements, recognised professional bodies, professional designations, and all related information such as registrations and accreditations.

“National Qualifications Framework (NQF)” is a comprehensive system approved by the Minister of Higher Education and Training for the classification, registration, publication and articulation of quality assured national qualifications.

“Non-formal learning” means planned educational interventions that are not intended to lead to the awarding of qualifications or part-qualifications.

“Notional hours of learning” comprise the total amount of time it would take the average learner to meet the outcomes defined in a learning experience and include *inter alia*, face to face contact time, time spent in structured learning in the workplace, time for completing assignments and research, and time spent in assessment processes.

“NQF Act” means the South African National Qualifications Framework (NQF) Act No. 67 of 2008.

“Occupational qualification” means a qualification associated with a trade, occupation or profession, resulting in learning in and for the workplace.

“Outcomes” means the contextually demonstrated end-products of specific learning processes which include knowledge, skills and values. Outcomes could be generic in that they could apply across many fields of learning (generic outcomes include aspects such as “ability to problem solve” or “understanding the world as a set of inter-related systems”).

“Progression” is the means by which individuals are permitted to move through NQF levels by accumulating appropriate combinations of credit.

“Provider” means a body that offers any education programme or trade and occupational learning programme that leads to a qualification or part-qualification registered on the NQF.

“Quality” means meeting the requirements of nationally agreed outcomes and performance/assessment criteria, thus facilitating both provision and monitoring.

“Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL)” means the principles and processes through which the prior knowledge and skills of a person are made visible, mediated and assessed for the purposes of alternative access and admission, recognition and certification, or further learning and development.

“Reliability” is the overall consistency of a measure. A measure is said to have high reliability if it produces similar results under consistent conditions. In assessment, reliability refers to the extent to which, in similar contexts, the same assessment-related judgements can be made.

“Replicability” means the extent to which assessment can be repeated and lead to comparable results in comparable settings.

“Statistical moderation” is a process of ensuring that the same assessment standards are applied to all learners doing particular studies. It includes the processes used to reduce sources of measurement error in assessment.

“Summative assessment of learning” means assessment conducted at the end of sections of learning or at the end of a whole learning programme, to evaluate learning achievements related to a particular qualification, part-qualification, or professional designation.

“Transparency” in assessment means the extent to which the assessment criteria and processes are known, visible to, and understood by learners and the various role-players in the assessment process.

“Validation” in assessment means any assessment-related activity or practice which relates to the credibility of the assessment by confirming that the assessment is assessing what it is meant to assess.

“Validity” means the extent to which the assessment measures what it has been developed to measure. Validity is about the appropriateness, usefulness and meaningfulness of assessment procedures, methods, instruments, and materials. Assessment is valid when assessment tasks actually test the knowledge and skills required for defined competencies and learning outcomes.

1. Background

Higher Health is a non-profit organisation focused on the health and wellness of the youth in the post-school education and training (PSET) sector. Higher Health's model of delivering health and wellness services is to empower PSET learners to take charge of their health and wellness, through education and knowledge. Higher Health's programmes are intense, and were delivered in-person. It soon became apparent that more learners could be reached if the programmes were offered online, via e-learning. Learners also wanted recognition for attending the sessions. Higher Health therefore developed its e-learning Civic and Soft Skills Programme, which the QCTO accredited as a NQF Level 5 Skills Programme. As Higher Health worked with the content for this Skills Programme, it became apparent that all the modules were inter-connected, and that good citizenship underpinned all of the learning. Hence, the module on civic education was included as the first module, and the inter-connected nature of the modules was highlighted in the curriculum design.

2. Purpose

- a. The purpose of this policy is to describe Higher Health's approach, methodology and strategy for the assessment of its skills programmes. The assessment strategy takes cognisance of having integrity, while being credible, fair, reliable, replicable, transparent, valid, and non-biased.
- b. The policy also sets minimum standards and provides guidance for effective, valid, reliable, fair, transparent and suitable assessment that has integrity.

3. Legislative and Regulatory Framework

This policy must be read in conjunction with

- I. QCTO OQSF Policy (2021);
- II. QCTO's RPL Policy (2021);
- III. General Principles and Minimum Requirements on E-Assessment of Qualifications and Part Qualifications on the Occupational Qualifications Sub-Framework (OQSF); and
- IV. SAQA's National Policy and Criteria for Designing and Implementing Assessment for NQF Qualifications and Part-Qualifications and Professional Designations in South Africa.

4. Scope and Application

This policy applies to Higher Health's skills programmes that are accredited as such by the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO).

5. Policy Statement

5.1 Principles

- a. Assessment is an integral part of the Civic and Soft Skills Curriculum; to the quality of the skills programme itself; and to its ability to ensure that its purpose and exit level outcomes have been achieved, thus paving the way for future articulation to other part-qualifications or qualifications registered on the NQF.
- b. The key assessment principles and practices employed are the following: Accountability; Absence of bias; Ensuring assessment range is assessed; Compliance to assessment standards; Proven competency to relevant outcomes; Credibility; Acceptable moderation practices for internal and final assessments; Fairness; Integrity; Reliability; Replicability; Sensitivity to language; Transparency; and Validity.
- c. Assessment is an integral part of teaching and curriculum development as the availability of outcomes and assessment criteria associated with them allows learners to understand what they need to learn.
- d. The achievement of both validity and reliability is enhanced through the development of assessment criteria associated with learning outcomes.
- e. Transparency and accountability are enhanced by the publication of assessment criteria as a task is set.
- f. Assessment functions as a powerful tool for learning when feedback on performance is provided, and learners are given multiple opportunities to pass.

5.2 Quality assurance of Internal and Final Assessments

- a. There are measures in place to verify that the quality and efficacy of the skills programme's internal and external assessments, align to the QCTO's assessment standards for all skills programmes.
- b. Internal assessments are based on the outcomes contained in the skills programme.
- c. Internal assessments use a variety of methods such as multiple choice questions, practical tasks and projects that test knowledge as well as the application of soft skills.
- d. All internal assessments are conducted online. Practical assessments are uploaded to the online platform and peer reviewed.

- e. A valid internal Quality Assurance and verification process for all internal assessments is conducted, which includes developing assessment plans, compiling regular moderator reports, and having routine checks in place to ensure that all assessments have been successfully completed.
- f. Internal assessments are viewed as part of the learning process, and learners get multiple opportunities to correctly answer the questions before proceeding with the course material.
- g. Summative assessments are completed for each module, and the learner will not progress to the next module without getting a minimum of 50% in the assessment.
- h. All results are recorded on the online system, and can be viewed as required.
- i. Learners receive a certification of participation per module.
- j. The learners must have successfully completed all modules before gaining entrance to the FISA assessment.
- k. All final assessments are developed and pre-moderated according to the relevant QCTO assessment standards.
- l. The FISA assessments are also taken online, with all precautions taken (proctoring) to ensure that the right learner is taking the assessment.
- m. Learners are provided with a specific code to enter the FISA assessments.
- n. Learners may take the 3 assessments at any time after completion of all modules, as long as all 3 assessments are successfully completed within a three-month period, and within their period of enrolment.
- o. Learners are allowed 3 attempts at each of the FISA assessments. If the learner fails to be declared competent after these attempts, then the learner should re-visit the programme learning material, and re-take all 3 FISA assessments.

5.3 Competency-based Assessments

- a. All final assessments are competency-based with a view to ensuring that learners have demonstrated their ability to perform at the NQF Level 5 exit level outcomes.
- b. Assessment standards are derived from learning outcomes.
- c. Being declared Competent in the final assessment means that the successful candidate would have been able to perform at the expected skill level, respond and react well to unexpected or new situations, and confidently fulfil the expected role in the workplace by applying their acquired skills, knowledge and experience.
- d. The competency-based assessments are designed such that a particular learner is able to display the required level of skills or capabilities, irrespective of the other learners. In other

words, learners are not competing against one another in the assessment: each learner is individually assessed based on his/her level of skills and competencies.

5.4 Content of Assessment

- a. The content of the assessment is informed by its purpose, as a systematic method of gathering evidence regarding the desired knowledge, skills, competencies, and values.
- b. All assessments take into account the relevant knowledge, skills and values; and relevant levels of cognitive challenge and complexity, as determined by the curriculum as well as the exit level outcomes.
- c. The following assessments are covered over the duration of the skills programme:
 - i. The reproduction of knowledge, skills and values (formative assessment)
 - ii. Application of knowledge, skills and values in known settings (summative assessment)
 - iii. Application of knowledge, skills and values in new contexts (integrated assessments); and
 - iv. New ways of doing, based on the application and development of knowledge and skills; and evidence of deep analysis, synthesis and understanding that enables making new connections (final FISA assessment).
- d. Only learners declared as 'Competent' in all modules will be allowed entrance to the FISA assessment.
- e. The FISA assessment consists of 3 online assessments, each with a different level of complexity.
 - i. The first assessment tests the application of knowledge, skills and values in known settings through a set of multiple choice questions (summative assessment).
 - ii. The second assessment tests the application of knowledge, skills and values in new contexts (integrated assessments) through the use of scenarios.
 - iii. The third assessment tests new ways of doing, based on the application and development of knowledge and skills, and evidence of deep analysis, synthesis and understanding, that enables making new connections, through the use of case studies.
- f. The FISA assessment is set according to the assessment standards for the FISA, as indicated in the Skills Programme document.
- g. All assessments are auto-marked, thus allowing the learner to know his/her results immediately.

5.5 Implementation of Assessments

- a. A learner will complete a declaration, confirming his/her identity and that s/he is indeed the learner registered and entitled to complete the FISA assessment.
- b. A learner will receive a passcode to enter the online FISA assessment.
- c. All three FISA assessments may be taken at any time within a three-month-period, with the learner in control of when each assessment should begin.
- d. The learner will have a specified time in which to complete each FISA assessment, after which the learner will no longer access that particular assessment.
- e. The learner will lose access to the FISA assessment platform after 24 hours of entry.
- f. All internal and external assessments are auto marked, thus ensuring consistency in the marking according to specified criteria.
- g. Assessments are transparent, with multiple opportunities afforded to candidates, to complete the assessments.
- h. At least 10% of each cohort of learners' marks, will be moderated by an expert moderator.
- i. All results will be communicated to the learner, and archived.
- j. Assessments will comply with the following criteria, thus deeming it fair:
 - i. Equal assessment opportunities for all learners regardless of their ethnicity, age, gender, culture, disability, social class, language or any other contextual features;
 - ii. Equitable assessment costs; and
 - iii. Transparent communication around fees charged for final assessments.
 - iv. This will be achieved in time, by offering the assessments in all 12 official languages; Offering all assessments online; Publishing the fees payable for enrolment on the course; and Including the FISA assessment fee with the cost of the skills programme.
- k. The FISA assessment may be taken at any time after completion of the modules, but within the enrolment period of the learner.
- l. Learners who are unsuccessful in their first attempt at the FISA assessments, may take the assessments multiple times, free of additional charges, as long as the learner is within his/her period of enrolment.
- m. If learners wish to take the FISA assessment outside of this enrolment period, then an additional fee will apply, mainly to cover the costs of re-registration onto the online platform.

- n. Learner enrolments must be submitted to the QCTO within 5 days after completing enrolments, in the format required by the QCTO, to allow for the QCTO compliance checks.
- o. The FISA assessments are auto marked. On successful completion of all three assessments, the learner will receive an electronic NQF Level 5 certificate, that is generated by the online e-learning platform.
- p. The QCTO and HWSETA will have direct access to all learner records, from the online platform, or data will be transferred to the QCTO in the required format, within 21 days after completion of the FISA assessment.

5.6 Assessment Irregularities

- a. Higher Health has an established structure and policy to manage irregularities.
- b. All irregularities are discussed internally with the EXCO, and steps are then taken to rectify the irregularities.
- c. All final FISA assessment irregularities must be reported to the HWSETA and the QCTO on the day of the irregularity, with specific reference to the nature and outcome of these irregularities.
- d. The final results of the relevant learner will be withheld, pending the finalisation of all investigations.

5.7 Approval of final results

- a. The QCTO approves final learner results, but has delegated this function to Higher Health. However, this does not negate the QCTO's responsibility in terms of certification.
- b. The QCTO will conduct regular and periodic checks on the assessment and certification processes to ensure that the processes meet the required standards.
- c. The QCTO may also review Higher Health's internal accredited assessments as the need arises.

6. Roles and Responsibilities

6.1 Higher Health

- a. The scheduling, administration, implementation, management and conduct (including the marking/assessment and moderation practices) of final assessments are the responsibility of Higher Health.
- b. Higher Health will inform the QCTO of planned FISA assessment dates, which will take place online.

- c. Higher Health must ensure that it is equipped to do the following:
- I. Develop management plans for final assessments
 - II. Maintain its learner online platform
 - III. Verify learner enrolments
 - IV. Conduct final assessments in accordance with the required standards
 - V. Keep accurate records of final learner results
 - VI. Transfer the certification information for the FISA assessment to the QCTO in the required format.
 - VII. Have a process that encourages continuous improvement and development of the curriculum offering
 - VIII. Publish FISA assessment dates
 - IX. Provide access to the final assessment guidelines and procedures
 - X. Provide access to brochures, or information on Higher Health's website that may assist the candidate in preparing for the final assessment.
 - XI. Grant access to information that can address final assessment-related queries, concerns, appeals, etc.
 - XII. Higher Health must communicate the list of learners on the skills programme to the QCTO, within 5 days of enrolments. All candidates must be registered on the QCTO database at the point of enrolment, with internal summative achievements for each module being recorded as completed (on a continuous basis).
 - XIII. Conduct formative and summative internal assessments per module, and provide learners with feedback on their performance.
 - XIV. Issue the candidate with a Statement of Results (SoR), following successful completion of all online modules, which indicates the candidate's competency in the achievement of all modules in all components of the skills programme. This is an admission requirement to the FISA assessment.
 - XV. Provide guidance, support and counselling services to assist candidates prior to, during and after the final assessment process.
 - XVI. Establish an appeal process for final assessment candidates to engage with final assessment related judgements.
 - XVII. Implement and administer the final assessment according to set quality assurance requirements.
 - XVIII. Record final results in the manner prescribed by the QCTO.

6.2 QCTO (Quality Council for Trades and Occupations)

- a. The QCTO will monitor the development, management and conduct of final assessments.
- b. The QCTO will also monitor the performance of Higher Health in terms of:
 - I. Capacity, planning, monitoring and evaluation of functions related to final assessments.
 - II. Quality assurance of marking/assessment and moderation practices, administrative records and reporting.
 - III. Irregularities, complaints and appeals procedures, and ongoing feedback to the QCTO on these processes.
 - IV. Any verification or audit processes implemented by the QCTO.
- c. Monitor the performance of Higher Health with respect to assessments conducted.
- d. Monitor and ensure the development of feedback mechanisms so that what emerges from assessment is fed into improving curricula and teaching practices
- e. The QCTO reserves the right to appoint an external moderator on any aspects of the final assessment process.

7. Appeals

- a. The notice of an appeal must state the grounds on which the candidate is seeking the appeal.
- b. Appeals about the final assessment process by candidates should be lodged with Higher Health, in accordance with Higher Health's Appeals Policy.
- c. An Appeals panel will adjudicate the appeal and communicate the outcome to the candidate.
- d. Where an appeal cannot be addressed to the satisfaction of all parties concerned, then the matter must be referred to the QCTO.
- e. The QCTO will make the final decision on what recourse is required to settle the matter, and the QCTO's decision is final.

8. Reporting

- a. Higher Health must report to the QCTO in the manner as prescribed by the QCTO.
- b. Where learner results are not submitted to the QCTO within 21 days of the date of the FISA, then Higher Health must provide reasons to the QCTO for the delay in reporting, and a timeframe by when the results will be submitted.

9. Applicability

This policy applies to Higher Health, its staff, consultants, and service providers who are part of the value chain of the Civic and Soft Skills Programme, and all learners who are enrolled on the Programme.